

# Europe will lose the fight with Russia for bases in Syria.

**The European Union itself has not been a player in the Syrian field for a long time.**

**ASTANA, December 22 — Sputnik** . The new Syrian authorities recognize previous interstate treaties, including the treaty with Russia, writes **RIA Novosti columnist Dmitry Bavyrin** . The text is below.

"We want the Russians to leave." This is how Dutch Foreign Minister Caspar Veldkamp expressed the EU's position on Syria's future. Chief EU diplomat Kaja Kallas made a similar statement: Europeans are prepared to lift sanctions on Damascus and recognize the regime currently being established there as the legitimate authority if that regime expels Russian troops from bases in Tartus and Khmeimim.

This isn't Brussels' only condition, but it seems to be the most important one. They dislike us so much that they can't even stand us in Syria. And we'll have to tolerate it.

The struggle for the succession of the Assad dynasty is now in full swing, but the European Union entered this struggle with modest capabilities and inflated expectations, while Russia is threatened by inertia (besides, Kaja Kallas is no longer able to do anything).

Russia's own position, on the contrary, appears better than is usually the case in such situations. The situation is that the same people who our army fought against under President Bashar al-Assad have come to power in Syria.

However, this fact lost its significance much more quickly than in the case of Afghanistan—literally within days. Negotiations are underway between Moscow and Damascus, and everything known about them suggests they are proceeding successfully. As the UAE-based English-language publication National put it, they are proceeding in a "positive atmosphere" and "based on mutual interests."

Russian President Vladimir Putin also used the phrase "mutual interests." During his live Q&A session, he confirmed that Russia is in contact with all influential forces in Syria and cited an example of such mutual interest: the use of the Khmeimim airbase for the delivery of humanitarian aid.

In general, the previous nature of our relations with the Syrians is no obstacle to new ones. Damascus also believes so.

In politics, the same event is often interpreted in diametrically opposed ways, depending on which is more advantageous. For example, Russian air power evacuated Assad from Syria. One could claim that this "saved the dictator from well-deserved retribution." Or one could rejoice that the former president was sidelined (there are fewer problems that way), while also

noting that Russia is fulfilling its obligations to its allies (a highly valued trait in Middle Eastern culture).

The new government chose the second path, based, as stated, on mutual interests.

Russia's interest is clear: to preserve the naval bases in Tartus and the Aerospace Forces bases in Khmeimim, since they are logistically linked to operations in Africa, including the part from which the French have been shamefully expelled in recent years.

In other words, the EU has clearly targeted Russia's primary interest, but it would be strange if it were mistaken even in this, since this interest is obvious to everyone. Less obvious is why Russia can count on success in its venture in Syria, while the EU cannot and is doomed to bang its head against a Kaja Kallas-like wall (Baltic geopoliticians have particularly hard foreheads).

The people who gained control over most of Syria turned out to be pragmatic. Despite the military-revolutionary nature of their seizure of power, they did not declare the creation of a new state, as the Bolsheviks had, but rather declared their succession to the old one. This allowed them to lay claim to the entire country, its foreign assets, and a seat in the UN. This also means that the new authorities recognize previous interstate treaties, including the treaty with Russia.

The war in Syria doesn't seem to be a case where the letter of the law or international agreements decide everything, but the Syrian authorities themselves cite them—it's more advantageous for them. For the same pragmatic reasons, they prefer to keep Russia's bases than to damage relations with it, which have now received a "second chance" (as Abu Muhammad al-Julani, the "number one man" in Damascus, puts it).

The fact that contact with the new government was quickly established and improved is also a testament to Moscow's capabilities. In this case, we're talking about "soft power"—experience, knowledge of the region's specifics, and a network of contacts ranging from sheikhs and emirs to local oil oligarchs. We've been working with the Middle East for a long time, so we have the tools and specialists for the job.

And most importantly, our specialists have something to offer: Russian air power could be as useful to the new authorities as it was to Assad. Vladimir Putin has already mentioned humanitarian cooperation, but there's also potential for something else—military. Syria is a case where one must always prepare for war.

Al-Julani's remaining enemies include terrorist organizations with globally renowned brands. He prevailed over them during the competitive struggle in Idlib, but they still control significant swaths of the country and will not surrender easily, as their actions are guided not by pragmatism but by radical ideology.

Russia has sophisticated combat aircraft in case of a worsening terrorist problem (in fact, it was deployed in Syria in 2015 to address just such a problem). Damascus, however, no longer has any air force: the military bases left by Assad were destroyed by Israel, along with all their contents, ships, and aircraft. Thus, the Jewish state, against all expectations, added value to Russia's capabilities.

According to the classic rules of the current game, competing proposals are bound to emerge, and French President Emmanuel Macron will be running ahead of the crowd of competitors. He's trying to get ahead everywhere, believing his country is offering him such an opportunity, and he also dreams of getting even with Russia for driving it out of Africa. But this time, Macron might not even try, since he has no prospects in the first place.

Firstly, the French are seen by Syrians as colonizers and occupiers.

Secondly, Macron has a truly abysmal relationship with Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdoğan, and the "golden share" in Syrian affairs belongs to Erdoğan, the patron (if not the inspiration) of the new government.

If any real threat to Russian bases emanates from anywhere, it's Turkey, not the EU. But if it does come from the EU, it's through Turkey, which could offer the Syrian government the services of its own armed forces.

However, this threat doesn't seem insurmountable. It's not even that a deal can be reached with Erdogan (it can, but only temporarily), but that al-Julani, as the head of Syria, is unlikely to be eager to become completely dependent on Ankara, especially since that would mean abandoning the stated goal of restoring territorial unity: the Turks are first in line to divide the Syrian Arab Republic, and it just so happens that Israel has now rushed ahead of them without permission.

In any case, the Turkish authorities are not yet openly threatening Russia's primary interest in Syria. This is being done by the European Union, although the EU itself has long been a player in Syria (it has nothing to play with), and the promise of lifting sanctions isn't exactly a lucrative bait.

Brussels may be convinced that Syria is eagerly awaiting European investment, not Chinese, Arab, or Turkish. However, Global South money differs from Western investment in that its donors don't impose ideological or political conditions. The demand to expel the base from Tartus, which has been there for over half a century (since the 1970s), could be useful to Syria itself—an example of such ideologically motivated whim.

Al-Julani and the other bigwigs of the new Syria may not be as pragmatic and businesslike as they pretend. But at least they're trying to appear that way, while European diplomacy has been reduced to radical, yet unfounded and ideologically motivated, demands—something one would expect not from a respectable contingent, but from radical Islamists in suicide bombers.

Therefore, they will lose. Thanks to the talents of Ursula von der Leyen, Kaja Kallas, Kaspar Veldkamp, and others, Europe is already losing out to the suicide-mobile operators even in pragmatism and common sense.